

**Molly Greene. *Catholic Pirates and Greek Merchants: A Maritime History of the Early Modern Mediterranean*. Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press, [www.pen-and-sword.co.uk](http://www.pen-and-sword.co.uk), 2010. 305 pp. Illustrations, notes, bibliography, index. US \$20.97, e-book; ISBN: 978-1-400834-94-5.**

To many North Americans, the term “pirate” is one with Caribbean origins, initiating reflection of the feared Black Beard, or the fictional Jack Sparrow. In this book, Molly Greene introduces generally unknown tales of piracy, tribunals, and territorial and religious discourse. *Catholic Pirates and Greek Merchants: A Maritime History of the Early Modern Mediterranean* is a historical summation of the mediterranean arena from the fifteenth to seventeenth centuries, with an extensive focus on the maritime movements of the Greek people, their varying roles in maritime history, and their interactions with the Ottoman, Venetian, Catholic, and Muslim actors who with the Greeks shared the mediterranean. Greene sets out to discover whether it was one’s strong religious sentiment or the duty as a sovereign subject to one’s state that determined one’s movements and actions in the mediterranean sea, and how these factors clashed in regards to the Catholic Greeks who sometimes found themselves to be Ottoman subjects. The first and second chapters lay out the Venetian and Ottoman order of the west-mediterranean sea during the sixteenth century and the resulting challenge by the Maltese Knights. The third chapter initiates the dive into piracy in the mediterranean, particularly focusing on Catholic pirates in Ottoman water after 1571. The last chapters, chapters four through seven, explore Mediterranean maritime history through a smaller scope, focusing on a group of merchants and their archival records as they confront Catholic power.

Molly Greene is a professor of history and hellenic studies at Princeton University. Her studies include that of the Mediterranean, the Ottoman Empire, and Greece, with additional experience teaching Balkan history. She has a bachelors in political science and a Phd in history where she studied the Ottoman Empire. It is likely that her years of research surrounding the topic of this book had given her a succinct understanding of Mediterranean maritime history, an understanding that, while reading, was clear she possessed, but did not often translate to the reader. There was an obvious lack of narrative that made this book particularly hard to follow. While Green laid out her arguments beautifully, the evidence tended to be a conglomeration of various accounts and events that often failed to flow together. Furthermore, this meant there was more historical summation than analysis. Though to the last point, when reading about a typically unknown part of history, it is fair to include a great deal of the historical events and detail them extensively (for Green, however, almost exhaustively). Additionally, Greene spent an excessive amount of time laying out these arguments, but waited until the conclusion to mention another viewpoint.

Despite these criticisms, it’s clear that this book is incredibly well-researched. Her extensive documentation, though sometimes difficult to digest, masterfully brings the actions and experiences of these merchants and pirates to life. Her ability to interconnect religious tensions, diplomatic issues, the bustling happenings of commerce, and piracy into a single book and then

reinforce these arguments with countless accounts and stories is beyond impressive. Likewise, the accounts also narrowed the narrative to examine history on an individual level. Molly Greene reemphasizes ambiguity multiple times, ambiguity of Greek identity, ambiguity of religious influence and status, ambiguity of Venetian subjecthood, and so on. In repeatedly stressing this ambiguity, and then offering various detailed, individual accounts to help clear this uncertainty, refocuses this period from simply one of vast empires to one of people: of *some* merchants, pirates, captains, passengers, and *some* muslims, and *some* Christians. Because as Molly Green repeatedly expressed, these individuals traversed the mediterranean confined not by religion or state, but an uncertain mix of both.

Molly Green's expertise truly shines through in *Catholic Pirates and Greek Merchants*, introducing readers to a multitude of historical events and forgotten stories. While the book's vocabulary and prose is generally acceptable for most readers, it is dense with specific historical accounts and an obscene amount of characters and dates followed by an extensive bibliography, notes, and index. Therefore, I would not recommend this book for casual readers, but believe it to be most suited for those with a deep interest in mediterranean and maritime history and perhaps those who even have some prior context in regards to the Ottoman empire or early modern period of the mediterranean basin. Those who possess a historical background will certainly appreciate the inclusion of multiple accounts, and thorough dig into the combined Ottoman, Greek, and Italian history. Likewise, those in search of primary and secondary sources for the mediterranean area in the fifteenth, sixteenth, and seventeenth century would find this book to be an essential tool for their research.